

Research Statement

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My thesis asks how the distribution of economic and political resources determines who holds political power, whether this affects the quality of policy through representation and political agency, and which democratic institutions matter for opening up access to political office to the broader population. These questions are as old as the study of politics. For Aristotle, oligarchy was rule by wealth and democracy a regime of the poor. The classical theory of elites held that every society is governed by an organised minority that reproduces itself, so that enfranchisement replaces one ruling class with another (Mosca, 1896; Pareto, 1916; Michels, 1911). Political economy formalised the mechanism: the wealthy hold office and set policy in their own interest, and policy shapes who becomes wealthy (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2000, 2008; Besley and Persson, 2011). The empirical literature has studied one side at a time, measuring what enfranchisement did to the budget without observing who sat in the legislature, or the background of legislators at one moment (Carnes and Lupu, 2023; Dal Bó et al., 2017). Nobody has watched a plutocracy end.

From probate and death records, Ellen Munroe and I have collected the wealth at death of every adult who died in England and Wales from 1858 to 1995, placing politicians, their families, candidates and the electorate on one scale across a democratic transition. This lets us ask whether plutocracy was representative, and why it ended.

Did enfranchisement lead to representation?

The literature on democratisation attributes the end of elite rule to the vote: once the poor can vote, policy follows them. **“Did Enfranchisement Lead to Representation?”** (Praninskas and Munroe, 2026a; job market paper) finds otherwise. Parliament drew on ever poorer families as the vote reached the poor, and half of that change is attributable to the franchise; but members already in office did not respond when the vote reached the poor in their own seats. What changed policy was who sat, not how sitting members governed. The poor entered Parliament only once trade unions and the Labour party paid for their candidacies, a generation after they could vote. Government for the people required a legislature of the people, and one formed only once the poor could afford to be in it.

Political dynasties and wealth

“Political Dynasties and Wealth” (Praninskas and Munroe, 2026b) asks which asset a dynasty transmits, inherited wealth or political capital, using changes in bequest taxation and close elections among first-time candidates. While the relative return to wealth has fallen, the relative likelihood of fathering an MP by acquiring office has increased.

Why the wealthy enter politics

In the Roy model of political entry of **“Pecuniary Selection or Incentives? Political Entry and Agency”** (Praninskas and Munroe, in progress), the wealthy may enter because they can afford to or because office pays them, with opposite implications for the competence and representativeness of legislatures and for reforms to the pay and cost of office. We identify both from the returns to office among winning and losing candidates.

References

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